

Choosing an audio player

The SDK ships three ways to play an audiobook. They exist for genuinely different integrations — this is why each one is there, and how to tell which one is yours.

Why there are three

One player would have to be either too rigid or too raw.

Playing an audiobook is not the hard part. The hard part is everything wrapped around it: resolving where the audio actually lives, checking the loan is still valid, making sure the same person is not listening on three devices at once, remembering the position, keeping audio alive when the phone is locked, putting controls on the lock screen and in the car, and reporting listening time — which is what the licence is billed on.

Every app integrating the SDK needs all of that. What they disagree about is **how much of the player they want to own**. Some want a screen to appear. Some have a design system that our screen would violate. A few already own an audio stack and need our books to play inside it.

So the three options are not three feature tiers. They are three answers to that single question, and each one hands you a different amount of the player:

- **The finished screen** — we own the whole thing.
- **The player without a face** — we own the behaviour, you own the pixels.
- **The engine itself** — you own everything except the parts only we can do.

THE ONE THING THAT NEVER CHANGES

Whichever you pick, the SDK still finds the audio, validates the loan, enforces one active device, plays downloaded books offline, and reports listening time. None of that is ever handed over — it cannot be, and you should not want it to be.

The three players

What each one is, and what you take on by choosing it.

OPTION 1

The finished screen

Hand it a book, get a working player.

```
WeDoBooksSdk.bookOperations.BookScreen(...)
```

A complete player screen: play and pause, scrubbing, skip, speed, chapters, sleep timer, a download button, and the notification your listener uses from the lock screen. You choose the colours and the wording; you are told when they close the screen or finish the book.

YOU OWN

- Colours, fonts and wording
- Navigation in and out
- Where tapping the notification lands

YOU GIVE UP

- The layout — it is our screen, built for full-screen portrait
- The notification's look and its buttons: cover, title and author, play/pause, skip 15 seconds. You cannot restyle it or add actions of your own
- Android Auto beyond playback controls — there is no browsable list of books, and you cannot supply one

OPTION 2

The player without a face

Our player, your interface.

```
WeDoBooksSdk.headlessAudioPlayer
```

Everything that works in option 1 keeps working — background playback, the notification, car and headphone controls, resuming where the listener stopped, pausing when they open the book elsewhere. Nothing is drawn — the interface is yours to build.

You get the commands a player needs — play, pause, seek, playback speed, position and duration — plus a live feed of what the player is doing. Chapters and downloads come from elsewhere in the SDK.

YOU OWN

- The entire interface, on every screen it appears
- Where tapping the notification lands

YOU GIVE UP

- The same two as option 1, because it is the same player: the notification's look and buttons, and Android Auto beyond playback controls
- Nothing else — the machinery underneath is identical

OPTION 3

The engine itself

The playback object, handed over.

```
WeDoBooksSdk.wdbAudioPlayerBuilder().build()
```

You get the player object and drive it however you like — drop it into an audio stack you already own, wire it to your own controls, run it somewhere no screen ever appears. We still do the parts only we can: finding the audio, checking the loan, offline playback, reporting listening time.

What we stop doing is running it for you. This is a plain player, not a managed session — it does not know the other two exist.

YOU OWN

- Playback control, end to end
- Your own notification — any layout, any actions
- Your own Android Auto integration, browsable catalogue included
- Background playback
- Resume position
- Shutting the player down

YOU GIVE UP

- Nothing is restricted — but nothing is provided either. Every item on the left exists only if you build it

THE COMMON MISTAKE

Option 3 reads as the premium tier, because it offers the most control. It is also the only one where audio stops when the listener locks their phone, no notification appears, car buttons do nothing, and the book restarts from the beginning instead of resuming. Those are not bugs — they are the responsibilities you accepted. If you cannot name which of them you need to control differently, you want option 1 or 2.

Which one for which app

Find the row that sounds like your integration.

YOUR SITUATION	USE	BECAUSE
Audiobooks are one feature among many — a library app, a school app, a reading catalogue	Finished screen	One call, correct on day one. The player is not where you should be spending design effort.
Evaluating the SDK, or building a pilot	Finished screen	Fastest path to hearing audio. Move to another option later if the design demands it.
You have a strong brand and our screen would look foreign in your app	Player without a face	Full freedom over your own screens with none of the behavioural cost. The notification stays ours.
You want a mini-player docked above the tab bar that expands to full screen	Player without a face	Our screen is one screen. A persistent mini-player is a layout we cannot provide.

YOUR SITUATION	USE	BECAUSE
Playback controls appear in several places — home screen, book detail, a widget	Player without a face	One shared player underneath, many surfaces observing it. No coordination work for you.
Your app already plays audio of its own — podcasts, radio, music — through one stack	The engine	You already own a playback session; you need our books inside it rather than a second one beside it.
You need playback behaviour we do not offer — unusual routing, custom mixing, your own session	The engine	The only option that lets you reach the player directly.
Short previews of books the listener has not borrowed	Any of the three	All three can play a sample, with no checkout needed.

Deciding in three questions

Answer in order. The first yes is your answer.

Do you already own an audio player that our books must play inside?

→ **The engine**

You have a podcast or music stack and one playback session for everything.

Does your design need a player we cannot draw?

→ **Player without a face**

A mini-player, controls spread across screens, or a look our screen cannot wear.

Otherwise.

→ **The finished screen**

You want a player, and you want it to work.

Moving between them later

Going from the finished screen to the faceless player is cheap: the machinery underneath is the same, so you are only replacing the interface, and you can even run both while you migrate. Going to the engine is a real move — background playback, the notification, car controls and resume position all become work you have to do. Plan that one; do not drift into it.

DO NOT MIX THE ENGINE WITH THE OTHERS

The finished screen and the faceless player are the same player underneath — they cooperate, and you can load a book with one and control it from the other. The engine is a separate player that knows nothing about them. Run it alongside the others and you will get two books playing at once, over each other.